

History of SIB Sabah

Sidang Injil Borneo Sabah · from 1928 to today

Portal SIB Sabah · November 2026

1. The Borneo Evangelical Mission

SIB began as the work of the **Borneo Evangelical Mission (BEM)**, founded in Australia in August 1928 by three young missionaries: **Hudson Southwell**, **Frank Davidson** and **Carey Tolley**. They came from Baptist, Anglican and Brethren backgrounds.

They reached Kuching in **November 1928**. The Rajah of Sarawak allowed them to work in Limbang, and the first big response came from the **Lun Bawang** people of the Limbang and Trusan valleys. Lawai Asi' was the first to be baptised, and **Racha Umong** believed on first hearing; he later became SIB's first President.

During the Second World War (1942–1945) all the missionaries were interned in Kuching, and Frank Davidson died in the camp. The churches survived because local believers kept leading them, which opened the door to local leadership.

2. The Gospel reaches Sabah

In **April 1937**, Hudson Southwell and **Stafford Young** made a survey trip through North Borneo (now Sabah), from Labuan to Tenom, Keningau, Tambunan, Ranau and Kota Belud. Stafford Young then began working among the Dusun of upper Tuaran.

A mission base opened in **Ranau** (1938–1939; sources differ on the year). Stafford Young was joined by **Trevor White** and later **Alan Belcher**. Few believed at first. One who did was **Kuntuni** (Kentuni Giwar), who kept preaching through the Japanese occupation.

Trevor White returned to Ranau in July 1946. The **first baptisms were on 25 December 1946**, and by the end of 1947 about 220 people from Nampasan and nearby villages had been baptised. The mission house at Takurik later became the site of SIB Pekan Ranau.



SIB memorial in Ranau (40th anniversary, 1959–1999).

Southern Sabah was reached separately, by believers from Lawas and Indonesia through Long Pasia. In 1949 Bible-school students went to **Sipitang**, and the Tagal people of Meligan asked to be taught. Local leaders also planted churches; forest ranger **Amin Gomboting** started an SIB church wherever he was posted.

3. From mission to church

The first pastors' conference was held in 1952 with only twelve pastors. By 1955 more than ninety pastors and their wives attended, from the Lun Bawang, Kayan, Kenyah, Dusun, Kelabit and Tagal churches.

At the **1959** conference the church took the name **Sidang Injil Borneo** for the evangelical church in Sarawak, Sabah and Brunei, with Racha Umong as President. SIB was registered under the Trustee (Incorporation) Ordinance, Cap. 148, on **1 September 1962**. At joint conferences a Sabah pastor usually served as Deputy President.

Ranau was the centre of SIB work in Sabah from 1972. On **10 December 1976**, to follow government rules, **SIB Sabah formally separated from SIB Sarawak** "in a spirit of brotherhood". Its headquarters then moved to Kota Kinabalu. Today the SIB Sabah office is at Jalan Saga, Likas.



Plaque for the SIB Sabah 50th anniversary event, Ranau, 8 October 2010.

4. Training leaders

- **Borneo Theological Seminary (BTS), Namaus, Ranau:** opened on 28 May 1965 as Sekolah Injil Latihan Namaus with 23 students. It became Sekolah Teologia Pertama (1974), Maktab Teologi Sabah (1993) and Borneo Theological Seminary (2018). It teaches in Malay, has 1,515 graduates and began a Master of Divinity in 2025.
- **BTS Melangkap, Kota Belud:** started in 1992 as an evangelism training centre for the interior, and became BTS Melangkap in 2018.
- **Sabah Theological Seminary, Kota Kinabalu (1988):** SIB is a member church. It was the first seminary in Malaysia to teach theology in Malay.

5. Growth



Gereja SIB Taginambur, Kota Belud district.

Year	SIB Sabah
1982	221 churches, 34,260 members, 76 pastors
2014	more than 500 churches, about 150,000 members
2026	about 760 churches (news report, March 2026)

The 1982 and 2014 figures come from Wikipedia without a cited source.

SIB Sabah worships in Malay, English, Chinese and local languages such as Dusun, Murut and Tagal. It also cared for the first SIB churches in the Peninsula until they became **SIB Semenanjung** in 2005.

6. How SIB Sabah is organised

- **Local church:** led by the Majlis Sidang Lokal, with ministries for children (PKK), youth (PMM), women (Wanita) and men (Wira).
- **Kawasan (area):** a Majlis Kawasan led by a Ketua Kawasan oversees the churches in its area. Portal SIB Sabah lists 728 churches in 42 Kawasan.
- **State (SIB Pusat):** led by the President, Deputy President, General Secretary and General Treasurer.



SIB Sapong, Tenom area.



SIB Pekan Telupid signboard: "Jadilah Saksi Kristus".

7. SIB Sabah today

- In January 2026 the 18th General Assembly elected **Rev. Dr Sintoh Yusop** as President for 2026–2028, succeeding Rev. Datuk Jerry Dusing.
- The 47th PMM youth conference (KPMM47), 1–3 September 2026 in Penampang, drew **4,600** participants.
- **10 December 2026** marks 50 years since SIB Sabah became its own church body.

Timeline

1928	BEM founded in Australia; missionaries reach Sarawak in November
1937	Southwell and Stafford Young survey Sabah
1938–39	Mission work begins in Ranau
1942–45	Missionaries interned; local believers lead the churches
25 Dec 1946	First baptisms in Ranau
1949	Gospel reaches Sipitang and the Tagal people
1959	Name Sidang Injil Borneo adopted
1 Sep 1962	SIB registered
28 May 1965	Bible school at Namaus opens (now BTS)
10 Dec 1976	SIB Sabah separates from SIB Sarawak
1988	Sabah Theological Seminary founded
1992	Training centre at Melangkap, Kota Belud
2005	Peninsula churches become SIB Semenanjung
2018	Borneo Theological Seminary name adopted
2026	Rev. Dr Sintoh Yusop elected President; 50 years of SIB Sabah

Notes, sources and photo credits

Some dates differ between sources: BEM founding (1927 or 1928), the start in Sabah (1937, 1938 or 1939) and the SIB name (1958 or 1959). This guide uses the dates most sources agree on.

Sources: SIB memorial plaque, Ranau; SIB Sabah website (2012 archive); Borneo Evangelical Mission, "Sejarah Sidang Injil Borneo"; C. Eilon, *Perkembangan Agama Kristian SIB dalam Kalangan Masyarakat Dusun Ranau (1937–2024)*, UMS 2025; Borneo Theological Seminary (btssib.com); Wikipedia; Daily Express (20 Jan 2026); TV Sarawak (9 Mar 2026); TV Sabah (5 Sep 2026).

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